The first time I ran for governor, I had had to overcome the argument that I was an actor without any experience in government. My eight years as governor had taken care of that. Now, in a presidential race, I knew we'd have to confront a different stereotype: the bias many Northeasterners held against Californians—the one that says since California is a land of fruit and nuts, it's a great place if you're an orange.

My theme on the campaign stump was familiar to anyone who had heard me speak over the years: It was time to scale back the size of the federal government, reduce taxes and government intrusion in our lives, balance the budget, and return to the people the freedoms usurped from them by the bureaucrats.

As we set off on the campaign trail, I attempted to tell Americans what we had accomplished in California to reduce waste and welfare abuse, and I proposed returning to states and communities direct control over a variety of federal programs such as welfare, aid-to-education, and housing, along with the taxing power to pay for them.

Our first battleground in the campaign was the New Hampshire primary in late February. I should have spent the weekend before the primary barnstorming New Hampshire, but instead John Sears arranged for us to leave the state and fly to Peoria, where I campaigned for the Illinois primary. Only afterward did friends in New Hampshire tell me that by leaving the state on the eve of the election, I'd sent a message to the voters of New Hampshire that I was taking them for granted, that New Hampshire wasn't important to me.

I lost the primary by fewer than 1,500 votes out of 108,000. We lost Florida, then the primary in Illinois, my home state. After three big losses so early in the campaign, the press began writing off my campaign, along with my